ul-Mulk and Abdun Nabi ‘to decide the amount of tax to be levied on Hindus’. It was not, however, a very long-lived order, disappearing as quickly, writes Badauni, as ‘a reflection on the water’. To put it in Iqtidar Alam Khan’s words, the 1570s ended with ‘a sudden collapse of the policy’ Akbar had espoused over the last decade and more: in 1579, Makhdum-ul-Mulk and Abdun Nabi lost their jobs; soon after, the jizya was removed once and for all.[38]

In 1580, Abul Fazl writes that Akbar rescinded some ‘taxes’. He does not specify what these were, but he does bring a narrative verisimilitude to the affair by connecting the dots with Akbar’s original attempt at abolishing taxes upon his accession – which the young emperor’s ‘veil’ and his underlings’ ‘avarice’ had rendered ineffective. Even if he doesn’t record the exact facts, then, the historian does convey an essence of the truth: in the 1580s, the tide of Akbar’s rule had turned.

It was in the 1580s, too, that Akbar began to remit taxes for reasons of economic, not social, justice. First in 1585, then in 1586, 1588 and 1590, the prices of crops fell across the empire – a result of increased agricultural production under Akbar’s new policies. Thanks to this deflation, however, farmers were unable to pay taxes on their produce. Each time, Akbar remitted their taxes, once by over 19 crore rupees. Such remittances were consistent with a policy of making the calculation, collection and distribution of the empire’s revenue more efficient and more just.

In late 1582, after the brainstorming during Nauroz, Akbar implemented Faizi’s suggestion and put various amirs in charge of keeping an eye on the prices of essential commodities. The list of these commodities is both eclectic and illuminating, covering, as it seems to, the needs of a broad swathe of society, from the soldier’s home to the commander’s mansion. Akbar’s milk brother Zain, for example, was put in charge of oil, and one Ghazi Khan Badakhshi in charge of salt – essential items by any reckoning – while the ill-tempered Shahbaz Khan, who quarrelled with Baba Qaqshal in Gujarat and with Aziz in Bengal, watched over the prices of brocade, and Hakim Abul Fath, the Persian émigré (fonder of bottles than battles as Badauni once put it), had charge of opiates. The list went on, spanning elephants and horses, grain and weapons, medicine, sheep and goats as well as silver and gold, books as well as perfumes – and in Abul Fazl’s special